

The Turning-65 Checklist

Eight steps, in order. Work from the top, check each box, and bring this page to any Medicare conversation. If one step trips you up, that is the one to ask about.

Your dates. My 65th birthday: _____ Window opens: _____ Closes: _____

☐ 1. Mark your 7-month Initial Enrollment Period

It runs the 3 months before your birthday month, your birthday month, and the 3 months after. If your birthday is on the 1st, everything shifts one month earlier. Write the real dates above.

☐ 2. Are you still working with employer coverage?

Still working at a company with 20 or more employees, on its group plan? You can usually delay Part B without a penalty. COBRA and retiree coverage do not count. Smaller company? You generally need to enroll at 65. Confirm this first, because it drives every step below.

☐ 3. Sign up for Part A

Hospital coverage is premium-free for most people with 10 years of Medicare taxes, so there is rarely a reason to wait. Enroll at ssa.gov, by phone, or at a Social Security office. If you already get Social Security, you are enrolled automatically.

☐ 4. Make the Part B decision carefully

Part B has a monthly premium. The late penalty is 10% of the premium for each full 12 months you were eligible and did not enroll, and it lasts as long as you have Part B. If you are delaying for employer coverage, make sure it qualifies (step 2).

☐ 5. Choose your path

Original Medicare (A and B) plus a Medigap supplement plus a Part D drug plan, or a Medicare Advantage plan that bundles it together. Medigap tends to mean more predictable costs and any-doctor flexibility. Advantage often means lower premiums and extra benefits, but it works through networks. Neither is right for everyone.

☐ 6. Do not miss your Medigap open enrollment window

Once you are 65 and have Part B, you get a one-time 6-month window where insurers cannot turn you down or charge more for health problems. Outside it, they can ask health questions in most cases.

☐ 7. Line up your prescriptions

Check each medication against any plan's drug list. Lists change every year. Use the list on the next page, with doses.

☐ 8. Confirm your doctors

"Takes Medicare" and "in my plan's network" are not the same thing. Check the plan's directory, then call the office and ask about the plan by name.

Your doctors

Doctor or specialist	Office phone	Confirmed in plan? (plan name)

Your prescriptions

Medication	Dose and how often	Covered on this plan? Cost?

Questions I want to ask

Want to go through this together?

Free, no obligation, in person around Greensboro or by phone.

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